language. The BJP's social-media warriors were the ones to originally start this game of verbal aggression, having successfully branded him as 'Pappu'. Now he was fighting back with slogans like 'chowkidar chor hai' (the guard is the thief).[54]

In fact, Gandhi's strategy was similar to what Modi had followed in his early years as chief minister, when his communications had a much more aggressive tone. As a prime-ministerial candidate in 2014, he shifted to greater use of sarcasm and wordplay, such as with his usage of the term 'shehzada' for Gandhi. He switched to a more statesmanlike tone on social platforms after becoming prime minister, leaving the hard messaging to the next rung of BJP leaders or to the trolls.[55] Even as prime-ministerial candidate in 2014, a comparative study found that Modi was much less insulting than global peers leading right-wing parties, such as US President Donald Trump in the 2016 general election, Nigel Farage in the 2016 UK Brexit referendum and Geert Wilders in the 2017 Dutch election.[56]

Modi was different from other global right-wing leaders, the study concluded. 'Narendra Modi practiced the gentle touch of innuendo with the highest level of wordplay in his tweeting, among all four,' the study said. 'In a context where the majority of social media users themselves are firmly part of the economic and social elite, Modi's Twitter output aimed to legitimize a populist movement by changing its off-street rhetoric. Unlike the other three politicians, Modi sits atop more than just an "establishment"—his political party is cadre-based and has deep roots in a community. Modi did not have to enact a populist agenda online to reach that base—it already came to him naturally through the RSS's wide network. For him, social media is a place for reserved populism. Unlike Trump or Wilders, he benefits from exhibiting restraint because his ability to wield the stick has never been in doubt.'[57]

The second big differentiator for Modi online is his focus on reaching out to celebrities. He focused on this right from his early years online when he started following a range of celebrities—from Rajinikanth in Tamil Nadu to Bill Gates in Silicon Valley to spiritual leaders like Baba Ramdev and Sri Sri Ravi Shankar. Over the years, he began broad-basing his messaging beyond the political, reaching out to cricket celebrities, as during the cricket World Cup in 2011.